

Laboratoire sur la

Prefiguration

Lab

Seven pedagogical innovations ideas for an engaging first-year B.Com. experience

Recommendations from a series of three
"prefigurative workshops" held in September 2025
at Telfer School of Management

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Executive summary

“Prefiguration” is about enacting here and now visions of a desirable future. Inspired by this concept, our report draws on a series of three “prefigurative workshops” held in September 2025 at the University of Ottawa’s Telfer School of Management. These workshops gathered senior B.Com. students (2nd, 3rd, and 4th year), full-time and part-time professors, as well as a range of pedagogical advisors* involved in the B.Com. program. Our core objective with this series of workshops was to generate a range of innovative ideas to make the first year of the B.Com. program more engaging by boosting its experiential content to adapt it to a rapidly changing world. The workshops were designed to empower the collective voice of students by putting them in the driver’s seat. Across the ideas that surfaced during our series of workshops, three key principles came up repeatedly, reflecting their importance for both students and instructors. These key principles are:

- shared ownership
- active participation
- collective learning

This report is intended as the starting point of a pedagogical innovation journey involving students and instructors, which we hope will continue and grow in years to come, nourishing a spirit of continuous improvement. While recognizing that some of the ideas presented here may appear far-fetched or impractical, or may already exist in some form, we hope they can inspire bold thinking and experimentation in and around the classroom. We focused on the first year of the B.Com. program because it is a pivotal moment where many students, gathered in 200-seat auditoriums, are transitioning from high school to university. Many of them feel alone in the crowd, somewhat lost and overwhelmed. For these reasons, we see the first year of the B.Com. program as a strategic moment where an engaging pedagogical experience can expand students’ imagination and inspire their life trajectories, preparing them to become leaders for a greener, healthier, happier, wealthier Canada, and a better world.

**** We use the generic term “instructor” throughout this report as a shorthand to include full-time and part-time professors as well as pedagogical advisors who participated in the workshops.***



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Methodology

The methodology adopted for the preparation of this report is inspired by the principles of participatory action research, which draws on the experiential knowledge of those affected firsthand by complex problems to envision and implement alternatives.^{1,2} The objective was to collect the perceptions, the expectations, and the unbridled imagination of students and instructors involved in the program to inspire a range of bold ideas that can make the program more engaging and better aligned with a rapidly changing world.

Three thematic workshops formed the core of the data collection.³

- **Workshop 1:** Gathered 14 dedicated instructors (full-time professors, part-time professors, and pedagogy professionals). It explored the realities of teaching, structural constraints, and levers of pedagogical motivation and recognition.
- **Workshop 2:** Gathered 20 students. Made it possible to understand their learning experiences, their perceptions of coherence between courses, and their expectations regarding the pedagogical relationship.
- **Workshop 3:** Gathered the 20 students and 14 instructors. Brought together the two groups to cross perspectives and identify shared solutions to improve communication and trust across the student and instructor communities, with the aim of fostering pedagogical innovation.

Professor Mathieu Bouchard facilitated the workshops with the contribution of research assistant Hamza Tawdi, a 4th-year B.Com. student. Each meeting combined small group discussions, plenary exchanges, and work with interactive visual aids (“post its”, idea boards, summary diagrams) to stimulate participation and ensure the traceability of contributions. The comments were collected in the form of observation notes, which we then analyzed to identify major themes emerging from the exchanges (motivation, consistency, student experience, pedagogical relationship, etc.).

Our analysis was based on a comparative reading of the three activity reports, highlighting the similarities, differences, and areas of tension between the ideas and perspectives expressed across the workshops. This approach ensures that recommendations reflect the main concerns and aspirations expressed by members of the Telfer B.Com. community.

¹ Cornish, F., Breton, N., Moreno-Tabarez, U., Delgado, J., Rua, M., de-Graft Aikins, A., & Hodgetts, D. (2023). [Participatory action research](#). *Nature Reviews Methods Primers*, 3(1), 34.

² Pettican, A., Goodman, B., Bryant, W., Beresford, P., Freeman, P., Gladwell, V., ... & Speed, E. (2023). Doing together: [Reflections on facilitating the co-production of participatory action research with marginalised populations](#). *Qualitative Research in Sport, Exercise and Health*, 15(2), 202-219.

³ Our participatory process made of three workshops, with the first two gathering students and instructors separately and the third bringing them together, was inspired by Mobasseri, S., Kahn, W. A., & Ely, R. J. (2024). [Racial inequality in organizations: A systems psychodynamic perspective](#). *Academy of Management Review*, 49(4), 718-745.



Idea 1 – Create a student-instructor pedagogy innovation committee

Communication between students and instructors is fragmented, limited to occasional exchanges, and often flowing unidirectionally from instructors to students. Students expressed the need for open dialogue with more structured opportunities to make their voices heard. Instructors, for their part, insisted on the need for a regular forum for consultation where sustained exchanges can take place to increase the flow of information and ideas across the student and instructor communities. Creating a student-instructor learning experience committee will serve that purpose by steering the implementation of Ideas 2 to 7, presented below in this report. It will facilitate the emergence and development of innovative approaches co-constructed by students and instructors, embodying the key principles of shared ownership, active participation, and collective learning.

"Often, we don't know how pedagogical decisions are made, or even why certain changes occur. A shared discussion space would give us the chance to be heard and to explain what we experience daily. It would create a climate of trust where everyone feels greater ownership and commitment to improving the program."

– Student

"In our classes, we often make instructional decisions with the best of intentions, but without always knowing how they are perceived by students. Having a structured space where their perspectives can be heard on a regular basis would help us better align our choices with their needs. This ongoing dialogue can promote mutual understanding and strengthen the coherence of the program. It can also help us prevent and address problems upstream."

– Instructor

Recommendation

To align the B.Com. program with the needs of its student community, regular and open dialogue between students and instructors must take place. A student-instructor learning experience committee would create a space for co-construction combining student and instructor perspectives. This committee will identify initiatives that can be implemented to promote teaching standards and pedagogical innovations that continuously improve the learning experience to the shared benefit of students and instructors.

Implementation

Set up a committee composed of five students and three instructors, ensuring a student majority that strengthens their collective voice and helps rebalance the inherent power dynamics of the classroom. Designate one instructor as a liaison to the Undergraduate Programs Committee (UPC) to ensure alignment and communication across governance structures. Convene the committee four times per year to support regular dialogue and sustained collaboration. Compensate student members and recognize instructor participation within their workload to value and legitimize their contributions.



Impact

The students and instructors build together at the intersection of their complementary perspectives, updating the UPC, which decides on implementation and ensures institutional alignment. This initiative nurtures a sense of shared ownership among students and instructors, strengthening mutual trust and commitment. It will also sustain a culture of ongoing pedagogical innovation through active participation of representatives from both the student and instructor communities.

Idea 2 – Develop a pedagogy mentoring program

The workshops highlighted the need to incentivize pedagogical innovation. Telfer instructors possess strong disciplinary expertise and commitment to students, but rapid changes in students' needs and educational technologies are widening the gap between content mastery and effective teaching practices. Doctoral students are a valuable resource yet need structured support to translate their knowledge into effective teaching practices.

"As students, you can tell immediately when a course is clearly structured and when the explanations genuinely guide you through the material. In some classes, you quickly understand where you are heading; in others, you remain a little lost even when you make the effort. When the instructor's approach is well adapted, it improves our ability to follow, participate, and stay motivated."

– Student

"Over the years, we have noticed that students learn differently and that some pedagogical approaches work better than others depending on the context. Having opportunities to discuss these practices and discover new methods would allow us to adjust what we do with greater precision. This would foster teaching that is even more attentive to students' needs, while respecting the diversity of our teaching styles."

– Instructor

Recommendation

Make pedagogy a pillar of professional development at Telfer by developing a mentorship program matching experienced instructors with a proven track record of engagement in the classroom with junior ones who can learn from them. Develop this as a formal certification pathway. This will leverage the tacit knowledge of experienced instructors while strengthening the confidence and skills of early-career instructors. In this way, pedagogy becomes a craft that is valued, supported among colleagues, and recognized like research is.

Implementation

Create a formal teaching mentorship program designed to strengthen pedagogical skills across Telfer. Make participation mandatory for PhD candidates after completing their comprehensive exam and open the program to any instructor who wishes to join. Establish a structured matching process that pairs mentors and mentees based on their interests, disciplines, affinities, and developmental needs, allowing mentees to shadow mentors through a full 3-credit course and engage in several reflective discussions. Recognize mentors' contributions within their workload and service and develop a formal certification pathway that validates mentees' participation and growth.



Impact

The teaching mentorship program will harness the expertise of accomplished instructors and share it across the faculty, elevating overall teaching quality. It will equip PhD candidates and less-experienced instructors with the skills and confidence needed to teach effectively, particularly in large first-year classes where the stakes and pressures are high. By transforming what can be an overwhelming experience into a supported and rewarding one, the program will strengthen instructor engagement and pedagogical readiness. This will foster a collaborative teaching culture and position Telfer as a leader in innovative and engaging business education.

Idea 3 – Create spaces where instructors exchange and learn from each other

Discussions among instructors during the workshops underscored the importance of preserving teaching autonomy while encouraging the exchange of effective pedagogical practices. Instructors value their freedom to teach in ways that reflect their style and expertise, yet they also express a strong interest in collaborating to expand one another's pedagogical toolbox. At the same time, the wide variety of teaching approaches across sections can create perceptions of inconsistency among students when it is not supported by structured dialogue and coordination among instructors.

"You can clearly see that each lecturer has a unique style, and we appreciate that. But sometimes the differences are so great that it is difficult to make connections from one course to another. When lecturers collaborate, it shows immediately. The courses complement one another better, the messages are more coherent, and you can sense a shared direction. Knowing that teachers have a place to exchange ideas would be reassuring."

– Student

"We know that each lecturer has their own way of organising a course, which is part of the richness of our faculty. However, students sometimes perceive these variations as inconsistencies rather than differences in style. More structured exchanges between instructors would clarify expectations. It would allow us to align with what our colleagues are doing and learn from each other without limiting our pedagogical freedom."

– Instructor

Recommendation

Create dedicated spaces where instructors can gather to exchange and learn from each other about their teaching techniques, innovative attempts, and struggles. Such gathering spaces will enable instructors to exchange, experiment, thereby collectively building their know-how and developing new joint initiatives that may not have otherwise taken place. Involve PhD candidates in exchanges and facilitation so that they learn from the collective and become skilled instructors early in their career.

Implementation

Bring instructors together in person in the morning with coffee and fruit, and online at noon to offer convenient options for participation. Organize these gatherings as regular monthly meetups of about 60 minutes at times that suit most instructors. This will require rotating



leadership from instructors for six-month terms, supported by administrative staff who coordinate logistics and communication. Construct and document a simple ritualized sequence of practices to structure each meeting, fostering comfort, intimacy, and the collective learning that emerges from sustained dialogue.⁴

Impact

This idea will enable vibrant exchanges among instructors across disciplinary siloes and seniority ranks, exposing them to a diversity of approaches, techniques, and designs for teaching. Doing so can enhance the quality of teaching across the board to the satisfaction of both students and instructors. Having dedicated spaces where instructors can learn from each other will sustain a culture of pedagogical innovation in the faculty.

Idea 4 – Turn the classroom into a space for collective learning

We live in an economy of attention. Students come to university with interactive and online learning habits. Students are exposed to a wide range of digital media (as we all are) and they disengage quickly when the pedagogical design and techniques do not surprise and involve them directly. Our workshops made it very clear that traditional one-directional lectures fail to attract and retain the attention of students. To get students engaged in a topic, the teaching format has to require their active participation in a set of activities that involve frequent interactions with the instructor and with each other. Having learned from their exchanges with students, seniors, and colleagues spaces dedicated to that intent as a result of ideas 1, 2 and 3, instructors are now prepared to turn the classroom into a collective learning space.

"What we want is a class where we do more than look at slides. When we discuss, analyse cases, or work in small groups, we retain much more and feel motivated. It is not that we reject lectures, we simply want to learn actively, through real dialogue."

– Student

"Students today learn differently; they want to participate, question, and get involved. Rethinking our courses by incorporating more interactivity would not only capture their attention, but also lead to deeper learning. We can maintain rigour while making the learning experience livelier and more connected to their reality."

– Instructor

Recommendation

Transform the classroom into a dynamic space for collective learning that builds trust between students and instructors by making the educational experience reciprocal. Allow instructors to guide the space and facilitate the process, enabling students to learn through active exchanges (both with the instructor and with one another) whether in plenary discussions, small-group debates, timely case analyses, or collaborative applied work. By engaging students directly in

⁴ For more on how establishing a ritualized sequence of practices enables collective learning, see Bouchard, M., Chreim, S., Langley, A., & Boivin, A. (2025). [Vulnerability Practices among Professionals in Multidisciplinary Settings](#). *Academy of Management Journal*, (ja), amj-2023.



this way, the classroom cultivates curiosity, agency, and a spirit of experimentation that enriches the learning experience.

Implementation

Structure each class around a concise cycle of exposition, application, and discussion, using simple participatory tools such as anonymous polls and cross-discussions to connect concepts to practice. Provide personalized pedagogical support to help instructors script sessions and design interactive activities aligned with learning objectives. Incentivize instructors to integrate these tools consistently so that classes evolve into active collective learning environments. Share innovative practices regularly within the collaborative spaces created through Ideas 1, 2, and 3, strengthening a culture of experimentation and continuous improvement.

Impact

Instructors are at the centre of this transformation, free to maintain their own style and equipped with the support needed to experiment and innovate confidently. Students shift from passive recipients to active partners in the learning process, developing a sense of shared ownership in the learning process that fuels students' active participation. Incentivized and supported by tangible resources, this idea turns the classroom into a space for collective learning to the benefit of students and instructors.

Idea 5 – Enable continuous feedback between students and instructors

The workshops revealed a need to nurture more open, reciprocal, and ongoing communication between students and instructors. Without regular feedback, a perception gap persists as students feel unheard while instructors lack timely input to adjust their teaching approach in real time. This lack of exchange creates an unnecessary distance, whereas sustained dialogue could significantly strengthen engagement and improve the learning experience.

"In many classes, we wish we could have given our opinion earlier, because some adjustments would really have made a difference for us. We are not trying to criticize for the sake of it, we just want the course to evolve while we are actually taking it. When feedback is possible along the way, you feel that your experience genuinely matters."

– Student

"End-of-term evaluations provide a good overview, but they arrive too late to help students currently in the course. I often think how useful it would have been to receive that kind of feedback earlier, so that I could adjust my pace or clarify certain points. Simple and regular feedback would allow quicker and more helpful adjustments for everyone."

– Instructor

Recommendation

Promote a culture of continuous feedback that strengthens mutual trust and supports genuine collaboration between students and instructors. When feedback is framed as a shared tool for learning and improvement rather than an assessment of competence, it becomes a catalyst for open dialogue. Through regular, constructive exchanges, instructors foster transparency and empower students to express their perspectives with confidence.



Implementation

Instructors administer short, anonymous pedagogical surveys (three to five targeted questions on pace, clarity, and workload) to gather timely insights directly from students. The confidential results are used solely by the instructor to adjust their teaching in real time. At the beginning of the following session, the instructor communicates the changes made to students, reinforcing trust and demonstrating the value of student input. To support this practice, Telfer implements a rapid feedback system integrated into Brightspace that is easy to use, confidential, and action-oriented.

Impact

By sustaining welcoming rapid feedback and adjusting to it in real time, instructors show students that they listen to them and adapt to improve the learning experience. Students, in turn, provide sincere and constructive feedback, while pedagogical advisors structure the system and facilitate the process to ensure that the practice runs smoothly and is recognized across Telfer. This tangible commitment from instructors to learning from students and adapting to their expressed needs strengthens mutual trust and fosters responsiveness, making courses more adaptive and relevant, channeling students' voices to make the classroom experience more engaging and satisfactory for both students and instructors.

Idea 6 – Design a year-long learning journey

The workshops highlighted that students tend to experience first year of the B.Com. program as fragmented and lacking a coherent narrative. New students arriving from high school, CEGEP, or abroad report feeling disoriented, lacking clear reference points to guide their transition into university life. Many describe their first year at Telfer as overwhelming, confusing, and stressful. Instructors, for their part, note that this sense of disconnection and uncertainty undermines the engagement of students and prevents them from performing to their full potential.

In the first year, we often feel lost, everything is new and no one really explains how the university works. An onboarding course would help us understand expectations, manage our workload better, and develop the confidence needed to succeed. It would greatly reduce stress and the feeling of isolation.

– Student

"Students arrive with very different backgrounds, and sometimes lack the foundations needed to succeed in a demanding university environment. An integration course would give them essential points of reference, such as methodology, time management, and academic engagement. It is a way of giving them a solid start and building coherence from the first week."

– Instructor

Recommendation

The first year of the B.Com. program should help students transition into university while giving them a clear and coherent understanding of the program's purpose. To provide meaning and continuity, first-year courses should be organized around a common thread that builds core analytical, ethical, critical thinking, reflective, and collaborative skills. A new for-credit integration course, tentatively called *Living and Learning at Telfer*, would anchor this coherence and support a smoother transition to university life. With the Library's expertise, the course



would offer structured opportunities for students to strengthen their ability to engage with and critically assess the business information environment relevant to their future careers.⁵

Implementation

Implement a mandatory, for-credit integration course that provides new students with an essential starting point, covering academic methodology, time management, intercultural communication, academic ethics, information literacy, business research skills, and available faculty resources. Establish a clear progression framework to sequence all first-year B.Com. courses according to a clear progression around core competencies such as analysis, communication, collaboration, and accountability. Create a correlation table to articulate learning outcomes across courses and reduce redundancies.

Impact

Empowering first-year instructors to integrate cross-curricular learning will create a coherent and meaningful pathway that anchors students' development from the start. Students will gain clearer guidance and a stronger sense of progress, helping them understand not only what they are learning, but why it matters and how it supports their future goals. With the administration ensuring cohesion and monitoring success through key indicators, this redesign will make the first-year experience truly foundational, strengthening motivation and fostering a shared sense of belonging within the Telfer community.

Idea 7 – Develop student-led learning spaces

Students face the persistent challenge of navigating between many platforms, services, and resources that are often disconnected from one another. This digital dispersion creates invisible barriers to engagement. The resources exist, but their lack of integration reduces their scope and undermine their efficacy. Instructors also express the desire to have a centralized space to better communicate, monitor student feedback, and promote educational initiatives.

"Many of us discovered clubs, services, or even study tools only at the end of the first year or later. It is not that they do not exist; we just come across them by chance. We often think that if we had known these things earlier, we would have experienced our first year very differently. Everything is there, but nothing is really organised or easy to find when you need it."

– Student

"A great deal of effort is made to make resources accessible, but I understand that the proliferation of platforms and channels can make things difficult for students. A clear entry point that brings together the essentials, especially at the start of the program, would be extremely helpful. A central structure would make orientation easier for students and benefit the entire community."

- Instructor

⁵ See how a related approach, developed in part by a research librarian, was implemented at McGill University's Faculty of Law (thanks to Telfer research librarian Cheng Yin Zhu for pointing this out): <https://focuslaw.mcgill.ca/welcome-new-cohort/>



Recommendation

As technology increasingly supports student autonomy, the Telfer experience should extend beyond the classroom into a lively digital space created with students. The goal is to give students a space that reflects them and brings learning, engagement, and innovation together. To do this, Telfer will develop the “Telfer Essentials” platform, integrated with Brightspace and supported by the Academic Department. This platform will centralize academic resources, support services, clubs, events, and faculty initiatives in one place.

Implementation

Define the platform’s architecture and functional priorities through a joint student–instructor–advisor group. Pay students skilled in web development and give them a leading role that empowers them to develop solutions that align with their experienced needs. Develop a “Library module” with the help of Telfer research librarians to highlight resources and/or events relevant to students (for example, many first-year students are not aware of the Financial Research and Learning Lab’s offerings beyond the computing space). Ensure day-to-day maintenance through the student committee, which handles updates, moderation, and coordination with support from advisors, while instructors contribute as content partners. Share an activity report every six months and organize user consultations to refine platform features. Sustain the platform’s relevance and actively train students in collaborative digital project management through this participatory governance model.

Impact

Students are positioned as active stewards of their learning environment, gaining autonomy and digital platform development and management skills, while shaping the online spaces they use to make them better integrated and aligned with their experienced needs. Instructors contribute to a dynamic flow of content and pedagogical innovation, while advisors guarantee coherence, security, and accessibility across the system. The “Telfer Essentials” platform becomes the digital public square of university life, fostering a culture of collaboration, mutual support, and experimentation that strengthens Telfer’s identity as a connected learning community.

Conclusion

In September 2025, we held three “prefigurative” workshops at the Telfer School of Management. Our goal was to enact here and now visions of a desirable future. Together, we rethought how we teach, learn, and collaborate. Bold ideas emerged. Instructors, advisors, and students engaged in deep dialogue and converged on the principles of shared ownership, active participation, and collective learning. This convergence reminded us that meaningful education comes from community, not hierarchy. Reinventing the first year of the B.Com. means giving the program coherence and purpose. It means using technology in wise and innovative ways. It means instructors and students learning together. It also means drawing on the deep expertise held across sections and departments to contribute, participate, and innovate together. With this shift, Telfer does not endure change – It shapes it. In doing so, the Telfer School of Management prepares its students to become impactful leaders for a greener, healthier, happier, wealthier Canada, and a better world.

